

Chapter 51-2

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At the old residence.

Ling Dang had a nightmare and woke up frightened, crying loudly after waking up. Sun Meirou hurried back to comfort Ling Dang.

Yu Wan stayed on the third floor to take care of the unconscious Qiu Zimin.

The two brothers, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe, went to the study.

Liang Xinhe's brain still hadn't processed this information, asking Liang Xinzhou in disbelief: "Big brother, is this true?"

Liang Xinzhou asked him back: "Does it matter whether it's true or false?"

"It's not that." The usually eloquent Liang Xinhe didn't know what to say for a moment. After pondering, he said: "Whether it matters or not, I still have the right to know the truth."

"It's true." Liang Xinzhou didn't hide it from him either. "You were still young back then. After Third Sister was lost, Dad and Mom had a very tense relationship, because it was Dad who took Third Sister out and lost her. Mom had just given birth not long before and showed some signs of postpartum depression. Later, the psychologist suggested she go out to clear her mind. When she came back, she brought Liang Shi with her."

"So where did Liang Shi come from?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Liang Xinzhou said: "She was found."

"Found where?" Liang Xinhe asked again.

Liang Xinzhou slowly shook his head: "I'm afraid only Mom knows about these things."

He had asked before, but Qiu Zimin only said she was found beside a trash can, looking so small and pitiful that she brought her home to raise.

Qiu Zimin wouldn't say anything more.

If he asked too much, Qiu Zimin would even find him annoying, saying what business was it of a child to manage so much?

Liang Xinzhou had no choice but to bury all of this in his heart.

"What about news of Third Sister?" Liang Xinhe asked. "Haven't we found her after all these years?"

"Mom and Dad have been looking, but there's no news. Those people are extremely cunning—they steal babies and sell them, some even across borders, disguising the stolen children's identities to smuggle them abroad. How could we possibly find her?"

Liang Xinzhou mentioned a heartbreaking incident: "It wasn't just our family that lost children in those years. President Gao, who went out with Dad back then, also lost a daughter. Because of this daughter, his wife divorced him, and he fell into deep guilt. A few years later, when the financial crisis hit and his company went bankrupt, he jumped off a building. They say he was still holding the pen his daughter had grabbed during her first birthday celebration¹ when he died."

Liang's father had also mobilized many connections back then, but found no clues.

Even the leads broke off at the foot of the mountain where they had gone to play. All signs pointed to it being revenge from business rivals.

After that, they could only blame themselves and feel guilty.

Back then, President Gao had spent almost everything searching for his daughter, but a child under one year old couldn't speak and would stop crying with just some food—the difficulty of searching increased exponentially.

Many years passed, technology became advanced, but the cases from years ago became cold cases.

"Recently I noticed that Dongling City cracked a human trafficking case, and some children were reunited with their families." Liang Xinhe said: "What if Third Sister was among them?"

"I've been following that case too. I've already had people investigate—no one meets the criteria." Liang Xinzhou said: "And..."

He paused, then asked very seriously: "Do you really want to find Third Sister?"

Liang Xinhe was stunned: "Shouldn't we look for her?"

"But have you thought about what would happen to Liang Shi if we found Third Sister?" Liang Xinzhou asked gravely.

The study fell silent.

The autumn rain began falling heavily, with large raindrops pattering against the glass. Fine droplets connected into streams winding down the glass before finally flowing to the ground.

Soon, a blinding flash of light streaked across the distant sky, tearing an irregular gash in the gray heavens.

A rumble of thunder followed.

Liang Xinhe's wandering thoughts returned. He understood the implication behind Liang Xinzhou's words.

—They wouldn't search anymore.

"But that's our real sister after all." Liang Xinhe frowned: "Mom and Dad have always wanted to find her, right?"

"After all these years, do you know what she looks like now? Even if we found her, would there be any feelings? If she came back, Liang Shi would definitely leave."

"Where would she go?" Liang Xinhe asked. "Even if Third Sister came back, Liang Shi would still be part of the Liang family. She has no other family members—everything she eats, uses, and lives in is provided by the Liang family. Where could she go?"

"She's acting now, isn't she?" Liang Xinzhou said.

Liang Xinhe was startled, then said dismissively: "How much money can she make from acting?"

"But haven't you noticed she's been cutting expenses?" Liang Xinzhou said: "She hasn't spent a penny on her credit card this month—everything has been from her savings account. I checked her bank statements, and in the past half month, she's only spent less than 1,500 yuan, including 300 yuan in gas."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

When the data was laid out before him, Liang Xinhe finally felt some sense of reality.

But he still didn't quite believe that Liang Shi, who had been spending money like water for so many years, could immediately change this habit.

"I think she's already preparing a backup plan for herself." Liang Xinzhou said: "She probably didn't just learn about this."

Liang Shi's emotions had been very stable, and when discussing this matter with him, it was like talking about someone else's business.

Her attitude was good, but carried a hint of indifference and distance.

"Liang Shi's arrival saved our family, so I owe her this debt of gratitude." Liang Xinzhou looked at Liang Xinhe: "She was also raised by both of us, and we have feelings for her. Even if she was a bit wild outside before, she never caused any major trouble. Moreover, now that she's changed for the better, why should we let another person come in and destroy the existing balance?"

Liang Xinhe fell into deep thought.

Footnotes:

¹ First birthday celebration (抓周): A traditional Chinese ceremony where a one-year-old child is presented with various objects to "grab," believed to predict their future interests or career path.